

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

21 May 2008

To National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

¹ As you may be aware, on 14 May 2008, six of the seven members of the Friends in Iran—the group that coordinates the activities of the Bahá'í community in the absence of a National Spiritual Assembly in the Cradle of the Faith—were summarily and unjustly arrested by the Iranian authorities. The seventh member had been arrested some weeks prior to this and also remains incarcerated. In this respect, the Universal House of Justice has directed us to extend to you its request for your action in defence of the Friends in Iran as follows.

² Immediately upon receiving news of the arrests, a selected number of National Spiritual Assemblies were asked to seek the intervention of their governments on behalf of the Friends in Iran and to bring this unconscionable action of the Iranian authorities to the attention of the mass media in their countries. Enclosed is a copy of that communication, dated 14 May 2008, for your information. The House of Justice has been most gratified to witness the strong statements that have been made by certain governments and non-governmental organizations, as well as the widespread coverage the mass media is giving to the story as a result of the efforts that have been taken to date by these National Assemblies.

³ The situation is perilous, and the House of Justice now calls upon you to undertake diplomatic and public information initiatives in defence of the Friends in Iran, to the extent that the circumstances in each of your countries allow. In this respect, your attention is drawn to the final paragraph of the above-mentioned letter to selected National Assemblies, which identifies the various spheres in which action is to be taken. Extensive background information regarding the persecution of the Bahá'ís in Iran may be obtained from the official Web site of the Bahá'í International Community at <<http://www.bahai.org/dir/worldwide/persecution>>. In addition, current news reports on this same subject are posted regularly by the Bahá'í World News Service at <<http://news.bahai.org>>.

⁴ It is appreciated that there will be a wide variation from country to country concerning what is both possible and wise to do. It is therefore left to each National Assembly's discretion to determine the nature and extent of its response to this call, mindful that the gravity of the matter demands that efforts be made to secure serious attention at the highest possible levels of government and the mass media.

⁵ You may feel confident that the Concourse on high stands ready to reinforce every step you take on behalf of these beleaguered and sorely wronged believers. The House of Justice will supplicate in the Holy Shrines that your devoted efforts may be guided and

bountifully confirmed.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]